

plications were equally bloody and horrendous. Terror became acceptable as a way of political life in some circles.

Scholars and long-time observers of Indian politics have noted how unprecedented Mrs Gandhi's political moves in Punjab were. Nehru, for example, never used religion in politics, keeping thereby the temperature of Indian public sphere in control. In the 1960s, Nehru had refused to allow the formation of a new Punjab state on religious grounds, despite Master Tara Singh's fast unto death. Punjab and Haryana were eventually reorganised into linguistically, not religiously, distinct states.



Two decades later, Nehru's daughter sought to exploit the religious divisions in the Sikh community for political gains. Religion, once unleashed as an electoral device right from the topmost tiers of the polity, engulfed all else in Punjab. Terror as a weapon of everyday politics was born and the state was plunged into a decade-long civil war.

The other quite awkward and controversial religious moment in politics in the 1980s arrived when the Supreme Court, pronouncing its judgment in the Shah Bano case, questioned both the validity of the shariat for Muslims as well as the competence of Muslim jurists and religious leaders to interpret the shariat. A secular court, having no expertise in centuries-long traditions of Islamic jurisprudence, showed incredible modernist hubris in condescendingly looking down upon believers. Caught in a Muslim furore and understanding it little, Rajiv Gandhi used his three-fourth majority in the Lok Sabha to overturn the court's judgment.

Thereupon, all hell broke loose. Viewing it as Muslim appeasement and smelling an opportunity for anti-Congress and anti-Muslim mobilisation, Hindu nationalists began to rouse large numbers of urban Hindus. In an attempt to pacify those so mobilised, the Government then allowed the re-opening of the Ram Janmabhoomi temple, a contested Hindu-Muslim site that had remained padlocked since 1948. Riots broke out and the Hindu nationalists launched a movement to "liberate" Ram Janmabhoomi and purge it of Muslim symbols, including the mosque at the heart of the site.

Looking back, it is clear that Rajiv's mistake stemmed from a misreading of religion. He was not unprincipled, simply politically innocent. Overturning the Supreme Court judgment, he thought, would pacify Muslims, and re-opening the temple, he inferred, would please the Hindus. What happened was something radically different: the reopening of the temple caused anxiety among the Muslims, and reversing the court judgment upset the Hindus.

Rajiv's other big contribution was, however, salutary. He was the first prime minister who knew what modern technology, market competition and private entrepreneurship could do to the country's economic uplift. Nehru understood the power of modern technology, not that of market competition; Indira understood neither; Rajiv understood both. India's economic policies were fundamentally transformed only in 1991, but Rajiv sowed the seeds of change. He brought in a new set of market-oriented economic advisers and placed them in positions of power. He was assassinated before the reforms could be put in place, but when the foreign exchange crisis of 1991 arrived, the new economic team and ideas he had nurtured were already in place, ready to execute the new vision, propelling India towards the economic revolution unfolding before our eyes today.

Despite the economic celebration Rajiv deserves, one can-

not but end on a note of anguish. Panchayati Raj was one of his pet projects. It is clear that he was right about adding the third tier of elected government to the country's governance. However, the execution was delayed until after his death and the powers of panchayats were insufficiently imagined. A fast accumulating body of research on China makes it plain that its economic revolution was led in the 1980s and 1990s by the so-called

Had Rajiv given greater power to panchayats, India's economic miracle might have lifted villages too.

Township and Village Enterprises (TVES). TVES were essentially village-based manufacturing units, led by local governments. They produced buttons, plastic bags, toys, shoes, simple radios, elementary calculators etc. If Rajiv had envisioned greater power—both financial and political, for India's panchayats, the nation's economic revolution might well have lifted villages as well, not simply the cities.

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